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American Express Banking Corp. is a leading global financial services company



PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

‘Set the strategy, bring others on board and do it right’

What was the problem you were grappling with?

As I worked my way up the corporate ladder from mid-management to senior leadership roles, I encountered a classic case of the ‘mindset change’ problem. Even though I was delivering on all the focus areas, it was seen as a matter of tactical, rather than strategic execution excellence. This started becoming an impediment to my career progression.

Whom did you approach for advice?

I approached my mentor Richard Petrino, Executive VP and COO of American Express National Bank.

What was the advice you received?

Petrino said that besides delivering results, I should also focus on three key leadership tenets: Set the strategy, bring others on board, and do it the right way. Typically, when we start our careers, we tend to focus on execution. As we evolve, our focus shifts to collaboration and inspiring teams. To deliver growth and strategic value, one must strike an optimal balance between setting the strategy, bringing others on board, and doing it the right way. I imbibed these lessons and created a blueprint for myself. For all the projects I lead, I first define the winning

strategy, engage with all the stakeholders and then focus on looking at various solutions before implementing the best one. My leaders were supportive and also invested in me by facilitating the training programme on ‘strategy’ from a premier institute.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

The advice made a big difference. I began approaching issues more comprehensively and strategically. The solutions were sustainable and contributed to the company’s larger goals. This strategy helped me in reaching my career objectives and developing my leadership skills. Since then, I’ve made it a point to help my co-workers develop leadership skills and advance in their careers. **BT**

—TEAM BT

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